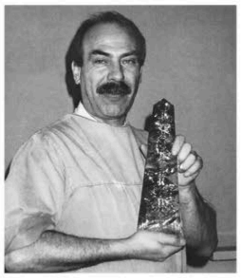


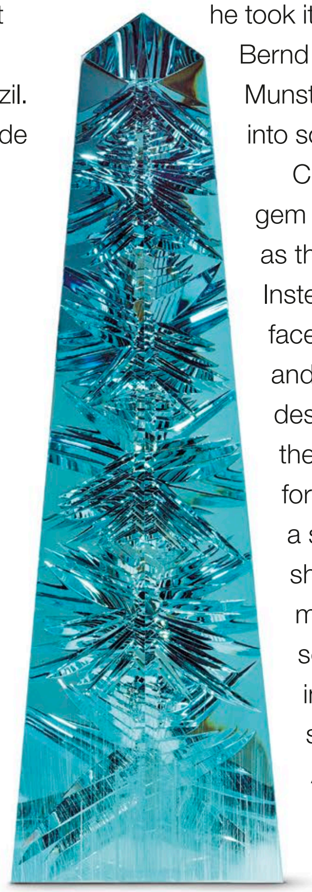
Dom Pedro Aquamarine

△ **Gem artist** Bernd Munsteiner, who cut the gem

The Dom Pedro is the largest known aquamarine gem in the world. It was fashioned out of an enormous crystal, discovered by three *garimpeiros* (independent prospectors) at Pedra Azul, in the Minas Gerais mining region of Brazil. Before the *garimpeiros* could decide what to do with it, however, they dropped it and the crystal broke into three pieces. The largest of these – which was around 60cm (2ft) in length and weighed about 27kg (60lb) – was eventually transformed into the Dom Pedro.

From the outset, there was a battle to preserve the crystal. In purely commercial terms, the most profitable outcome would have been to cut it up into small gems to be sold off, and this was the intention of the original Brazilian owner. However, the crystal came to the notice of Jürgen Henn, a German gem dealer. Immediately struck by the exceptional size, clarity, and colour of the piece, he organized a consortium of investors to purchase the crystal and transport it to Idar-Oberstein, a famous gem-cutting centre in southern Germany. There, he took it to his friend, the gem artist Bernd Munsteiner, knowing that Munsteiner could turn the crystal into something truly remarkable.

Coming from a long line of gem cutters, Munsteiner is known as the "father of the fantasy cut". Instead of using traditional flat facets, he incorporates grooves and cleverly curved facets into his designs. Munsteiner worked on the aquamarine crystal by hand for more than six months, making a series of tapering, lozenge-shaped cuts. The result is this magnificent, obelisk-like gem sculpture that reflects the light in such a way that it almost seems to glow from within. As a tribute to its Brazilian origins, he named it the Dom Pedro, after the country's two emperors who ruled during the 19th cenury.



Full view of the Dom Pedro Aquamarine

Key dates

1822–2012

- **1822** Dom Pedro I (1798–1834) becomes the first emperor of Brazil
- **1841** Dom Pedro II (1825–91) is crowned as the second and final emperor of Brazil

Dom Pedro I

- **1960s** Bernd Munsteiner pioneers the "fantasy cut", a radically new form of gemstone carving
- **Late 1980s** Three prospectors unearth a huge aquamarine crystal in Pedra Azul, Brazil
- **1991** A German gem dealer, Jürgen Henn, examines the crystal and photographs it
- **1992** A consortium organises the purchase of the crystal and transports it to Germany
- **1992–93** In "the project of his life", Bernd Munsteiner transforms the crystal into a spectacular obelisk
- **1993** The Dom Pedro is revealed to the public at a gem fair in Basel, Switzerland
- **1996** Jane Mitchell brings the obelisk to the US, exhibiting it at Palm Beach
- **1999** Jane Mitchell and Jeffery Bland purchase the Dom Pedro
- **2011** The obelisk is donated to the Smithsonian Institution, in Washington, DC, USA
- **2012** The Dom Pedro is placed on permanent display in the National Gem Collection Gallery at the Smithsonian

> What **Mother Nature** has made **large** and **beautiful**, we should not make small

Jürgen **Henn**
Gem dealer